01 · HOST PLANNER

Four-Week Countdown

PARTY DATE _____ GAME _____

Write the real date in each box, then tick tasks as you go. Starting late? Do the starred tasks first.

4 Weeks Before

WEEK OF

- [ ] Pick a game that fits your guest count and occasion ★
- [ ] Set the date, start time and guest list
- [ ] Send invitations with an RSVP date ★
- [ ] Decide on dinner, buffet or finger food
- [ ] _____

2 Weeks Before

WEEK OF

- [ ] Chase RSVPs and confirm final numbers ★
- [ ] Assign a character to every guest
- [ ] Send each guest their character intro and costume hint
- [ ] Plan the menu and drinks
- [ ] _____

1 Week Before

DATE

- [ ] Print booklets, clues, name tags and ballots ★
- [ ] Read the host guide from start to finish
- [ ] Order or gather props, candles and decor
- [ ] Make a party playlist
- [ ] _____

3 Days Before

DATE

- [ ] Shop from your shopping list
- [ ] Ask a friend to cut and envelope the clue cards, so you can play too ★
- [ ] Fill in the award certificates
- [ ] Send guests a friendly reminder
- [ ] _____

Day Before

DATE

- [ ] Prep food that keeps overnight
- [ ] Set up Detective HQ and the evidence table
- [ ] Practice reading the opening aloud
- [ ] _____

Day Of

DATE

- [ ] Lay out name tags, pens and ballots ★
- [ ] Keep the solution sealed until the reveal
- [ ] Light the candles and start the music
- [ ] _____

HOST TIP

The Host Planner file (Murder-Mystery-Host-Planner.html) fills in these dates for you: enter your party date and it counts back every task.

NOTES & REMINDERS

_____

_____

_____

Guest & Character List · 1 of 2

Guests 1–20

RSVP column: Y = yes, N = no, ? = maybe. Add the character from your game, plus costume ideas and what each guest is bringing.

#	GUEST NAME	RSVP	CHARACTER	COSTUME	BRINGING	NOTES
1						
2						
3						
4						
5						
6						
7						
8						
9						
10						
11						
12						
13						
14						
15						
16						
17						
18						
19						
20						

QUICK COUNT

Yes: _____ Maybe: _____ No: _____ Characters still to assign: _____

Guest & Character List · 2 of 2

Guests 21–40

Bigger group? Pairs or small teams can share one character. Note who is paired with whom in the last column.

#	GUEST NAME	RSVP	CHARACTER	COSTUME	BRINGING	NOTES
21						
22						
23						
24						
25						
26						
27						
28						
29						
30						
31						
32						
33						
34						
35						
36						
37						
38						
39						
40						

TOTAL GUESTS

Guests 1–20: _____ Guests 21–40: _____ Final count: _____

Party Budget

TOTAL BUDGET _____ GUESTS _____ PER GUEST _____

Fill in the Planned column before you shop and the Actual column after. Per guest = total ÷ number of guests.

#	ITEM	PLANNED	ACTUAL	NOTES
1	Game kit or download			
2	Printing, paper and card stock			
3	Food			
4	Drinks			
5	Candles and decor			
6	Props and costume bits			
7	Prizes for the awards			
8	Name tag holders and pens			
9	Envelopes and party supplies			
10	Music or streaming			
11				
12				
13				
14				
15				
	TOTAL			

SAVE MONEY

Print booklets on plain paper in black and white and keep card stock for name tags and certificates. Ask guests to bring a dish that fits their character.

WHO OWES WHAT / SHARED COSTS

Shopping List

GUESTS _____ SHOP BY _____

QUANTITY RULES (ROUND UP)

Name tag holders: 1 per guest + 2 spare
Envelopes: 1 per guest + 4 for the evidence table
Card stock: 1 sheet per 2 guests + 12 for awards
LED candles: 1 per 2 guests
Soft drink / juice: 1 two-liter bottle per 4 guests
Appetizers: 5 bites per guest (3 for a 60-minute party)
Pens: 1 per guest + 2 spare
Printer paper: 8 sheets per guest + 20
Small prizes: 1 per 3 guests + 1
Sparkling drink: 1 bottle per 3 guests
Ice: 1 bag per 5 guests
Napkins: 3 per guest

GOT	QTY	ITEM	STORE	COST
☐				
☐				
☐				
☐				
☐				
☐				
☐				
☐				
☐				
☐				
☐				
☐				
☐				
☐				
☐				
☐				
☐				
☐				
☐				

Menu Planner

STYLE _____ SERVE AT _____

Choose food that guests can eat while they mingle and talk. Dishes that keep overnight free you up on the day.

WELCOME DRINK

_____

_____

_____

APPETIZERS

_____

_____

_____

MAIN COURSE

_____

_____

_____

SIDES

_____

_____

_____

DESSERT

_____

_____

_____

ALCOHOL-FREE DRINKS

_____

_____

_____

Dietary Needs

#	GUEST	NEEDS (ALLERGY, VEGETARIAN, NO ALCOHOL…)	DISH THAT COVERS IT
1			
2			
3			
4			
5			
6			

THEME IT

Give each dish a mystery name on a little card: Alibi Sliders, Red Herring Dip, Prime Suspect Punch, Final Clue Cupcakes.

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Party-Night Run Sheet

START TIME _____ LENGTH _____

Write a clock time next to each step and who leads it. Follow your game's host guide for the exact number of rounds.

TIME	WHAT HAPPENS	WHO LEADS	DONE
	Guests arrive: name tags and drinks		☐
	Host reads the opening and the rules		☐
	Round 1: mingle in character		☐
	Food is served		☐
	Round 2: new clues and questions		☐
	Final round: the evidence table		☐
	Accusations: everyone fills in a ballot		☐
	The reveal: host reads the solution		☐
	Awards and a group photo		☐
	Party wraps up		☐
			☐
			☐
			☐
			☐

SAMPLE TIMINGS (MINUTES AFTER START)

90 minutes: arrive 0 · opening 15 · round 1 at 20 · round 2 at 40 · final round 60 · ballots 72 · reveal 78 · awards 85 · end 90.
150 minutes with dinner: arrive 0 · opening 20 · round 1 at 30 · dinner 60 · round 2 at 80 · final round 105 · ballots 120 · reveal 130 · awards 140 · end 150.
60 minutes: arrive 0 · opening 10 · rounds at 15, 27 and 39 · ballots 47 · reveal 52 · awards 57 · end 60.

Day-Of Setup Checklist

DOORS OPEN _____

Set up each zone, then tick it off. Finish 30 minutes before guests arrive so you can get into costume too.

Entrance

- [ ] Name tags and holders
- [ ] Pens in a cup
- [ ] Guest & character list for check-in
- [ ] Sign for coats and bags
- [ ] _____

Detective HQ

- [ ] Detective notebooks
- [ ] Spare pens
- [ ] Blank ballots
- [ ] A box or jar for ballots
- [ ] _____

Evidence Table

- [ ] Clue envelopes, still sealed
- [ ] Table sign and any props
- [ ] Good lighting to read by
- [ ] A clear path around it
- [ ] _____

Bar & Food

- [ ] Drinks, ice and glasses
- [ ] Alcohol-free options labeled
- [ ] Napkins and plates
- [ ] Dish name cards
- [ ] _____

Host Kit

- [ ] Host guide and opening script
- [ ] Solution in a sealed envelope
- [ ] Timer or phone (on silent)
- [ ] Award certificates and prizes
- [ ] _____

Ambience

- [ ] LED candles placed safely
- [ ] Playlist queued
- [ ] Lights dimmed a little
- [ ] Seats for everyone at the reveal
- [ ] _____

LAST-MINUTE JOBS

_____

_____

_____

PLAY ALONG AS HOST

Ask another guest or family member to cut the clue cards and seal them in envelopes, so you never see the clues before the party. Then you can guess along with everyone else.

After the Party

DATE _____ GAME _____ GUESTS _____

Fill this in the next day while it is fresh. It makes next year's party twice as easy.

#	AWARD	WINNER
1	Super Sleuth	
2	Most Convincing Liar	
3	Best Costume	
4	Best Red Herring	
5	Closest Guess	
6	Best Accent	
7	Best Dramatic Performance	
8	Most Suspicious Behavior	
9	Best Alibi	
10	Life of the Party	
11	Best Supporting Player	
12	Master of Disguise	

WHO SOLVED IT? BEST THEORY OF THE NIGHT

THANK-YOU NOTES TO SEND

WHAT WORKED

CHANGE NEXT TIME

Choosing a Game: Questions to Ask

Use these questions to compare any murder mystery game before you buy. Write your answer for each.

#	QUESTION	WHY IT MATTERS	OUR ANSWER
1	**How many guests, and could the number change?**	Pick a game whose player range covers your low and high count.	
2	**Are the roles gender-flexible?**	Lets you cast friends freely, whatever the mix.	
3	**Can the host play too?**	Some games need a host who knows the answer; others let you guess along.	
4	**How long is the game: 60, 90 or 150 minutes?**	Match it to dinner, drinks or a lunch hour.	
5	**Seated dinner or mingling?**	Mingling games need space to walk; dinner games work at the table.	
6	**Does the theme fit the occasion?**	Christmas, New Year, Halloween, a birthday or any time.	
7	**Is the content right for this crowd?**	Check it is office-safe or kid-friendly if you need it to be.	
8	**How much printing is there?**	Count pages per guest and the host pages.	
9	**What if someone cancels?**	Look for a list of roles you can drop without breaking the puzzle.	
10	**How much costume effort will guests make?**	Simple costume hints help everyone join in.	

NOT SURE YET?

Enter your guest count and occasion in the Host Planner file. Its Game match section suggests a Clue & Candle game that fits your group.